

Unit 1, Option E/F: The Expansion and Challenge of Nationalism

Topic E/F1: The Road to Unification: Italy, c1815–70

The main focus of this option topic is on the process by which Italy became a single unified state. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question focused on why Italy was unified in the years 1859-70 would clearly draw on the roles of Cavour and Garibaldi (bullet 2), the interaction of France and Austria (bullet 3), the methods adopted (bullet 4) and the role of Prussia (bullets 3 and 4). Students might also wish to refer to the lessons learned in 1848-49 (bullet 1). It is therefore important that students should be aware that collectively the bullet points offer a framework for identifying and investigating the main issues and themes of nationalism and conflict related to Italian unification and that they understand the links and interaction between them.

The first bullet point focuses on the growth of liberal and nationalist sentiment in Italy in the years following the Vienna Settlement of 1815. Students should understand the provisions made for Italy in the treaty, the ways in which they secured Austrian power across the peninsula, and the resulting growth of opposition to autocratic and foreign rule. This can be illustrated by reference to failed attempts at revolution in the period and the revolutionary ideas of reformers such as Mazzini. They should be aware of the contribution of economic grievances, especially in the 1840s as a result of poor harvests and early industrialisation. They should understand the outbreak of further revolutions in 1848, and the lessons that could be learned from their failure.

The second bullet point relates to the part played by key individuals in the process of unification after 1850. Students should understand the roles played by Cavour, Victor Emmanuel and Garibaldi. They can exemplify this, for example, by reference to the significance for unification of Cavour's reforms within Piedmont as well as his foreign links, and of Garibaldi's role in the war against Austria in 1859-60 and his ensuing intervention in Sicily and Naples. Students should also be aware of the importance of the Church as a political factor in Italy, and in particular the role of Pope Pius IX in obstructing unification to 1870.

The third bullet point relates to the role of foreign powers in these events, particularly Austria and France. Students should understand the concept of the balance of power and how it affected the fate of Italy but questions will not be set on events outside Italy in this period. They should understand the significance of Austrian and French intervention in Italy, specifically in 1848-49 and 1859-61, and of their continuing presence across the period.

The fourth bullet point focuses on the process of unification in the years 1859-70. Students should be aware of the main stages by which the Italian states came together in 1859-61, 1866 and 1870. They should understand the roles of Piedmont and France in defeating Austria and uniting the north, and of Garibaldi in the conquest of the south. They should be aware of the role of Prussia in the acquisition of Venetia and Rome. Students should also have an understanding of the social, cultural and geographical divisions which continued throughout these years and which affected the extent of unity achieved in these years.
